

Resilience Across Borders: Tracing the History, Culture, and Modern Struggles of Borneo's Dayak Civilization

This report provides a comprehensive analysis of the Dayak civilization, encompassing the diverse indigenous peoples of the island of Borneo. It examines their historical development, cultural practices, social structures, spiritual beliefs, and the profound contemporary challenges they face. By synthesizing archaeological, anthropological, and sociopolitical research, this investigation explores the resilience and adaptability of Dayak societies as they navigate the pressures of modern nation-states, large-scale industrialization, and global environmental change. The analysis emphasizes the historical roots of Dayak identity, its transformation under colonial rule, and its dynamic expression in the present day, while also placing the Dayak experience within a comparative framework alongside other indigenous civilizations in Southeast Asia.

Historical Origins and Colonial Transformation

The history of the Dayak people is a narrative spanning tens of thousands of years, marked by deep ancestral roots in Borneo, complex patterns of migration, and profound transformations brought about by colonial powers ¹²⁴. Understanding this history requires examining the deep-time presence of humans on the island, the formation of collective identities, and the lasting impacts of Dutch and British colonization. Archaeological discoveries at Niah Cave in Sarawak provide foundational evidence for an ancient human presence, with remains dated to between 40,000 and 44,000 years ago, making them some of the earliest anatomically modern human fossils found anywhere in the world ^{88 89 92 94 174}. These findings establish that the ancestors of today's indigenous populations inhabited Borneo during the Late Pleistocene epoch ¹⁶⁹. While direct genetic continuity is a complex area of study, some research suggests a potential ancestral link between these ancient remains and modern indigenous groups, including the Dayak ⁹⁵. Further studies confirm a deep ancestry connection, with proxies suggesting a time depth exceeding 7,500 years, indicating a long-standing relationship between the people and the island's environment ^{54 160}.

The broader regional context is defined by the Austronesian Expansion, a significant prehistoric migration originating from Taiwan around 6,000 years ago [57](#) [164304](#). Genetic and linguistic data indicate that Austronesian-speaking peoples arrived in Borneo approximately 3,500 to 4,500 years ago, significantly shaping the island's population genetics and language families [55](#) [123166](#). This expansion had a strong genetic and linguistic impact across Island Southeast Asia [162255258](#). However, this was not a simple replacement of existing inhabitants. Evidence suggests a process of admixture with earlier, non-Austronesian populations, potentially including Austroasiatic-related groups, which is reflected in the linguistic similarities between some Land Dayak languages and Aslian languages spoken in Peninsular Malaysia [60](#) [63](#). This layered history of deep residency and subsequent migration is fundamental to the remarkable diversity observed among Dayak groups today. Before colonial intervention, the interior of Borneo was a mosaic of distinct ethnic and linguistic groups, each adapted to its specific environment [3](#) [68](#). Groups known collectively as Land Dayaks, such as the Bidayuh, inhabited the western lowlands and riverine areas, while others developed different livelihoods [139168](#). Longhouses served as the central hub of communal life, housing multiple families and functioning as centers for governance, defense, and social activities [139265](#). Trade was also a vital component of pre-colonial life; archaeological findings in the Sarawak River delta reveal that the area was a thriving center of trade between India and China from the 6th century CE onwards [67](#).

The term "Dayak" itself is not a primordial ethnic label but a relatively recent construct, primarily shaped by colonial administrations and subsequently adopted by indigenous leaders for political purposes [9](#) [175](#). Historically, the term may have denoted non-Muslim indigenous peoples living away from the coast, distinguishing them from Malay and other Muslim groups [136175](#). During the 19th and early 20th centuries, both the Dutch in Kalimantan and the British in Sarawak and North Borneo applied the term broadly to categorize the myriad of inland ethnic groups [71](#) [167](#). Scholars note that a sense of a unified, bounded, and politicized Dayak ethnicity emerged in step with the rise of the modern colonial state and the spread of Christianity [202](#). In response to perceived threats from coastal powers and later, Javanese encroachment, Dayak leaders began to use the term "Dayak" to forge trans-border solidarity [126194](#). This political consolidation was evident in movements calling for greater autonomy, most notably the post-World War II push for a "Great Dayak" territory, which led to the formation of West Kalimantan province in 1957 with a Dayak majority [38](#).

Colonial rule introduced sweeping changes that fundamentally reshaped Dayak societies. The introduction of new religions, particularly Protestant Christianity, was one of the

most significant transformations. Beginning in the 1830s, the Dutch colonial administration actively encouraged Protestant missionary activity among Dayak communities ³⁴. The Rhenish Missionary Society began its work on the island in 1835, and later, the Borneo Evangelical Mission (BEM) became highly influential in northern Sarawak from the 1930s ^{35 37 221}. This led to widespread conversion, creating deep-seated religious divides, most notably between Christian Dayaks and those adhering to the indigenous faith of Kaharingan ³⁸. This division sometimes fueled conflict, as seen in the anti-Christian rebellion against Dutch forces in the 19th century, where the conversion zeal of missionaries provoked an anti-Christian jihad ¹⁴⁸²²³. The colonial legal systems established in Borneo diverged significantly between the Dutch and British spheres of influence. In Malaysian Borneo (Sabah and Sarawak), the British introduced Native Courts designed to adjudicate disputes according to customary law, a system that continues to exist today ^{26 205263}. In contrast, the Dutch abolished sultanates and placed Indonesian Borneo (Kalimantan) under direct military control, subordinating *adat* (customary law) to the authority of the state ²²⁰²⁸⁷. This divergence has had enduring consequences for the legal status of indigenous land rights and self-governance in the two parts of the island.

Cultural Expressions and Spiritual Worldviews

The cultural and spiritual life of the Dayak people is characterized by a rich tapestry of artistic expression, deeply held animistic beliefs, and a remarkable capacity for adaptation through syncretism. Kinship serves as the bedrock of social and political organization, influencing everything from residence patterns to resource distribution ⁶ ⁷. Many Dayak groups, such as the Selako, are organized around cognatic (bilateral) kinship systems, where descent and inheritance are traced through both male and female lines ³. This contrasts with patrilineal systems and creates complex networks of affinity and obligation that form the basis of community cohesion ⁵. Artistic traditions are vibrant vessels for cultural identity, cosmology, and social memory. Dances like the Iban Ngajat are quintessential expressions of Dayak heritage, performed during festivals to celebrate bravery and mimic the movements of the hornbill bird ^{77 155}. This dance, along with others like the Kadazandusun Sumazau and various ritual dances of the Kayan and Lundayeh peoples, is accompanied by distinctive music often featuring large gong ensembles ¹⁵⁶²²⁷²²⁸. The Gandang Ahung, a sacred gong ensemble, holds particular spiritual significance, being central to the Tiwah death ceremony of the Kaharingan faith ^{72 217}. Tattoos, known as *kelingai* among the Iban and *tedek* among the Kayan, are far

more than decorative body art; they are powerful symbols of identity, social status, courage, and spiritual protection [80](#) [85](#) . Specific motifs carry deep meanings: the *bunga terung* (eggplant flower) signifies maturity and bravery, while other designs represent ancestral connections and spiritual concepts [82](#) [299](#) . For Kayan women, the application of tattoos is a rite of passage that marks their capability to undertake adult responsibilities and signifies their cultural knowledge [84](#) [152](#) .

The spiritual landscape of the Dayak is dominated by their indigenous religion, Kaharingan, a complex animistic belief system centered on ancestor veneration and reverence for the spirits of nature [50](#) [53](#) . Kaharingan, which means "water of life," is an animistic folk religion practiced predominantly in Central Kalimantan [51](#) [142](#) . Its core revolves around maintaining a harmonious relationship with the spirit world and upholding *adat*, the sacred cosmic order. The most important ritual is the Tiwah ceremony, a thirty-day festival involving the sacrifice of numerous animals, which is performed to guide the souls of the deceased to the afterlife [214215216](#) . This elaborate ceremony underscores the centrality of ancestorship in Dayak cosmology [266](#) . The journey of Kaharingan towards formal recognition highlights the complex relationship between indigenous identity and the nation-state. In Indonesia, the government officially recognized Kaharingan as a form of Hinduism in 1980, a move that was both an acknowledgment of its existence and a strategic co-optation by the state, which constitutionally recognizes only a limited number of religions [144230274](#) . This decision reflects a broader pattern where states seek to fit indigenous belief systems into predefined monotheistic frameworks, a challenge faced by many indigenous religions globally [145146](#) .

The arrival of Christianity and Islam has created a dynamic and often tense spiritual environment, characterized by both conflict and syncretism. The extensive missionary work of the 19th and 20th centuries led to the conversion of large segments of the Dayak population, particularly the Iban and other groups in Sarawak [37](#) [149](#) . This religious divide has sometimes been a source of conflict, but it has also fostered the emergence of hybrid spiritual identities [38](#) . Syncretism is a dominant trend, where converts to Islam or Christianity continue to participate in traditional cultural rituals and maintain beliefs in local spirits [30](#) [297](#) . This blending of faiths has resulted in new cultural identities, such as the Senganan Dayak of West Kalimantan, who practice a variant of Islam infused with local customs [27](#) [28](#) [31](#) . Conversion narratives often emphasize moral transformation, with Christian Dayaks stressing how their faith has instilled new values of love and compassion [32](#) . Despite this, the underlying connection to ancestral traditions remains strong, reflecting a deep integration of indigenous beliefs with cultural identity that

persists even among those who identify with Abrahamic religions ³⁰. Shamans and other ritual specialists continue to play a vital role as intermediaries between the human and spirit worlds, performing healing rituals and guiding the community in maintaining spiritual balance ¹²⁵²³⁹.

Social Organization and Traditional Governance

The social fabric of Dayak communities is intricately woven from the threads of kinship, customary law, and traditional leadership. At the heart of Dayak social and political organization lies the principle of kinship, which defines individual roles, responsibilities, and relationships within the community ⁶. Among many groups, such as the Kanayatn, kinship structures signify respect, generational hierarchy, and familial roles, creating a complex web of obligations ^{4 10}. The social structure of Dayak societies is often described as consisting of highly fluid and flexible units based on these kinship ties ⁸. Residence patterns can be matrilineal or patrilineal depending on the group, but cognatic systems, which recognize ties through both parents, are prevalent and influence marriage rules and social alliances ^{3 5}. This emphasis on extended family networks is physically embodied in the longhouse, a communal dwelling that historically housed multiple related families under one roof, serving as a unit for daily life, governance, and mutual defense ¹³⁹²⁶⁵. The construction of a longhouse was a community-wide effort, reinforcing social bonds and collective identity ²⁶⁵.

Traditional governance among the Dayak is rooted in consensus-based decision-making and the wisdom of elders, rather than hierarchical authority ¹². Leadership is often exercised by respected individuals or councils of elders who guide the community in accordance with *adat*, the body of customary laws and traditions passed down through generations ²⁶⁴. These leaders, sometimes titled *Tumenggung* in certain contexts, act as primary executors of *adat* and mediators in disputes ¹³⁷. This model of leadership, which emphasizes collaboration and community well-being, stands in contrast to more centralized, top-down models of governance ^{15 16}. In recent times, there has been a proliferation of customary Dayak titles, which serve to elevate the role of elders and signify authority and status within the community ¹⁴. However, the authority of these traditional leaders is increasingly tested by the demands of modern politics and the pressures of national governance systems ^{65 103}. Despite these challenges, the revival of *adat* has become a significant force in contemporary Indonesian politics, with Dayak

leaders leveraging traditional custom to advocate for greater autonomy and the protection of their rights ²⁶⁸.

The interaction between traditional governance and state legal systems varies significantly between Malaysian and Indonesian Borneo. In Sabah and Sarawak, the legacy of British colonial rule includes the establishment of Native Courts, a unique feature of the legal system designed to adjudicate disputes concerning native customary law ^{26 208}. These courts handle matters of land, marriage, and succession according to *adat*, providing a parallel legal framework to the civil and Syariah courts ²⁰⁶²⁶³. While these courts offer a crucial mechanism for upholding indigenous norms, their jurisdiction and effectiveness are subject to the overarching authority of the state and are often constrained by bureaucratic hurdles and legislative restrictions, such as prohibitions on non-natives holding land under Native Customary Rights (NCR) ¹³¹²⁰³. In Indonesian Borneo, the situation is different. Under Dutch colonial rule, the state systematically undermined the authority of traditional leaders and subordinated *adat* to state law ²²⁰²⁸⁷. After independence, the Indonesian state continued this centralizing tendency, though it has recently shown some willingness to recognize indigenous rights, particularly following landmark Constitutional Court rulings affirming that customary forests belong to indigenous communities, not the state ^{40 43}. Nevertheless, the process for formally recognizing customary territories remains arduous and slow, forcing communities to engage in protracted legal battles and advocacy efforts to secure their ancestral domains ^{40 47}. This tension between customary governance and state law is a defining feature of the contemporary Dayak experience, shaping their strategies for political mobilization and cultural preservation.

Agroforestry and Environmental Stewardship

The agricultural systems of the Dayak people represent sophisticated models of agroecology, demonstrating a deep understanding of forest dynamics and a commitment to sustainable land management that is intrinsically linked to their spiritual worldview and cultural identity ¹⁰⁵²⁴⁹. Traditional shifting cultivation, often referred to as *swidden* agriculture, is a cornerstone of Dayak farming ¹²⁰. Contrary to the pejorative label of "slash-and-burn," this practice is a regenerative system ¹¹⁸. When fields are abandoned, they enter a fallow period during which secondary forest naturally regenerates, using the functions of the forest ecosystem to replenish soil fertility without the need for external inputs ¹⁷⁸. This cyclical process maintains soil health, supports biodiversity, and

contributes to regional food security, with traditional swidden systems forming the output base for large areas in countries like Indonesia, Thailand, and Vietnam [183](#). Beyond simple swiddening, many Dayak groups practice integrated farming systems. For example, integrated rice-fish systems, which are used across Southeast Asia, enhance crop yields and provide a valuable source of protein for the community [179181](#). The Dayak Simpan community in West Kalimantan cultivates fruit trees on land previously used for shifting agriculture in a system known as 'tembawang', showcasing another layer of complexity in their agroforestry knowledge [47](#).

Land and resource management among the Dayak are governed by a combination of customary law (*hukum adat*) and spiritual beliefs, which together create a robust framework for environmental stewardship [47](#). Certain natural features—such as mountains, rivers, and patches of forest—are often considered sacred and are protected by taboos (*ngalayo*) that prohibit their destruction or disturbance [47](#). For the Dayak Simpan, for instance, the Gunung Juring mountain and the Riam River are sacred, and beliefs hold that desecrating these sites will bring disaster upon the community [47](#). These taboos function as powerful, community-enforced conservation mechanisms that are more effective than many top-down regulatory approaches [282](#). The Dayak Benawan people of East Kalimantan possess local knowledge embedded in their rituals, which carry symbolic meanings related to maintaining cosmic balance and ensuring the sustainability of natural resources [289](#). This demonstrates how local wisdom is not merely a set of practical techniques but is deeply integrated with a cosmological understanding of the relationship between humans and nature [229250](#). Women farmers, in particular, are often the custodians of agrobiodiversity, preserving heirloom seeds and managing diverse crops that are crucial for climate adaptation and nutrition [185](#). The loss of this traditional knowledge represents a significant threat to both cultural heritage and agricultural sustainability in the region [182](#).

The contemporary struggle for land rights is inextricably linked to the survival of these traditional agroforestry systems. As large-scale commercial plantations, logging concessions, and mining operations expand into indigenous territories, they disrupt the fallow cycles essential for soil regeneration and destroy the sacred groves that serve as critical reservoirs of biodiversity [40 48](#). The Dayak view the forest not just as a resource, but as a fundamental part of their identity and existence. As one Dayak elder poignantly stated, "If the forest is destroyed, it's we who suffer... When someone dies, we take wood for the coffin and rattan [from the forest] to tie it together." Destroying the forest is, in their view, destroying the very essence of Kalimantan itself [40](#). In response to these threats, there is a growing movement to formally recognize and protect customary forests

(*hutan adat*). Indigenous organizations like AMAN (Alliance of Indigenous People) are working to map and register millions of hectares of forest on behalf of their communities, seeking official decrees that would grant them legal authority over their ancestral lands ⁴³. Securing this status empowers communities to manage their resources sustainably, protect sacred sites, and build resilient local economies based on nontimber forest products and agroforestry, thereby safeguarding both their culture and the environment ⁴⁷. This fight for land is therefore a fight for the continuation of a way of life built on principles of harmony with nature.

Feature	Description	Significance
Swidden Agriculture	Regenerative farming system involving clearing and cultivating small plots of forest followed by long fallow periods.	Replenishes soil fertility naturally, maintains biodiversity, and supports food security without external inputs ¹²⁰¹⁷⁸¹⁸³ .
Integrated Systems	Includes practices like rice-fish farming and the cultivation of fruit trees within shifting cultivation landscapes (e.g., 'tembawang').	Enhances yields, provides additional protein sources, and diversifies household income ^{47 179181} .
Sacred Groves & Taboos	Certain areas of forest, rivers, or mountains are designated as sacred and protected by customary prohibitions (<i>ngalayo</i>).	Functions as a powerful, community-enforced conservation mechanism to preserve critical ecosystems and biodiversity ^{47 282} .
**Customary Forests (<i>Hutan Adat</i>)	Formal legal recognition of indigenous land tenure granted by the state, giving communities authority over their ancestral forests.	Provides a legal basis for protecting land from industrial encroachment and managing resources sustainably ^{43 47} .
Indigenous Knowledge**	Deep, place-based knowledge of local flora, fauna, soil types, and seasonal patterns accumulated over generations.	Essential for adaptive agricultural practices, pest management, and overall ecological resilience ^{185249 250} .

Contemporary Challenges and the Struggle for Rights

In the contemporary era, the Dayak people face a confluence of existential threats driven by large-scale industrial development, demographic shifts, and the erosion of their legal rights and cultural integrity. At the heart of these challenges is the relentless pressure on their ancestral lands. In Indonesian Borneo (Kalimantan), the path to securing formal recognition of customary forests (*hutan adat*) is arduous and slow, despite landmark 2013 Constitutional Court rulings affirming that forests belong to indigenous communities, not the state ⁴³. The bureaucratic process for obtaining official decrees is complex, leaving communities vulnerable to land grabbing and corporate exploitation ⁴⁰. In Malaysian Borneo (Sabah and Sarawak), the legal framework for Native Customary Rights (NCR) offers a degree of protection, but these rights are frequently undermined by weak governance, corruption, and the prioritization of economic development over

indigenous tenure ¹³¹¹³². Companies often operate on customary lands without prior consent, using flawed Environmental Impact Assessments to legitimize their actions and dispossessing communities of their livelihoods ^{40 48}. This has led to escalating conflicts, with communities resorting to direct action, such as when protestors seized bulldozers from a timber company in West Kalimantan ⁴⁸.

A primary driver of conflict and marginalization has been the Indonesian government's transmigration program, initiated by the Dutch and expanded after independence ⁴². This policy involved relocating millions of people from densely populated islands like Java, Bali, and Madura to less populous regions like Kalimantan. This massive demographic shift created intense competition for land and resources, fostering resentment between the incoming migrants and the indigenous Dayak populations ⁴². This simmering tension erupted into horrific violence, most notably the Sampit conflict in 2001, which resulted in over 500 deaths and the displacement of more than 100,000 Madurese migrants ⁴². Researchers attribute this violence to a combination of factors, including economic desperation, jealousy of the newcomers' economic success, and the end of Suharto's authoritarian rule, which had suppressed such ethnic tensions ⁴². These events underscore the fragility of multicultural coexistence when underlying grievances and unresolved land rights issues are ignored.

In response to these multifaceted threats, the Dayak have mounted a determined struggle for rights, cultural revitalization, and political recognition. Legal battles are a central strategy. Dayak communities, supported by organizations like the Sarawak Dayak Iban Association (SADIA), are using innovative methods such as GPS mapping to document their territories as irrefutable legal evidence in court cases against corporations and the state ^{39 44}. In Indonesia, the Alliance of Indigenous People (AMAN) has played a crucial role in advocating for *hutan adat* rights, successfully helping communities register millions of hectares of forest ⁴³. Political activism is another key front. Organizations like Bansa Dayak Sarawak (PBDS Baru) and the Borneo Dayak Forum (BDF) are not only fighting for legal rights but also for the cultural affirmation of Dayak identity, urging the Malaysian government to recognize Dayak traditional attire for official functions and promoting the importance of cultural displays as part of a broader struggle for dignity and self-determination ^{20 46}. Community-led conservation represents a third pillar of resistance. Groups like the Dayak Tomun in Lamandau have pioneered efforts to secure legal recognition for their territories, while the Dayak Kenyah Oma'lung protect their Tana Olen ('Forbidden Forest') and collaborate with international programs like REDD+ to conserve their environment ^{38 43}. These initiatives demonstrate a proactive approach, where the defense of culture and the protection of the environment are understood as two sides of the same coin. The resilience of the Dayak people is evident in their ability to

strategically navigate complex legal systems, mobilize politically, and reclaim their cultural heritage in the face of immense adversity.

Comparative Perspectives on Indigenous Civilizations in Southeast Asia

The experience of the Dayak people, while unique in its specific historical and cultural details, shares significant parallels with the trajectories of other indigenous civilizations across Southeast Asia. These comparisons highlight both the common challenges faced by indigenous peoples in the region and the distinct characteristics that define the Dayak case. Like the Dayak, many indigenous groups in Southeast Asia have endured a shared history of colonization, land dispossession, and marginalization by newly formed nation-states [108201](#). The Orang Asli of Peninsular Malaysia, for example, have faced similar struggles for land rights, with colonial-era legal systems inherited by the post-independence government continuing to erode their customary tenure in favor of state-controlled development projects [103110114](#). Similarly, the Ainu of Japan experienced centuries of harsh policies aimed at assimilating them into Japanese society, which included the banning of their language and traditional ceremonies and the seizure of their ancestral lands, known as 'Ainu Mosir' [41](#). These experiences reflect a broader pattern where the imposition of Western-style state sovereignty and legal frameworks has systematically disadvantaged indigenous claims to land and self-governance [188285](#).

A common challenge across the region is the pressure to assimilate into a dominant national culture, which often comes at the expense of indigenous languages, traditions, and identities [110111](#). The Dayak have faced similar pressures, particularly from large-scale settlement programs like Indonesia's transmigration, which altered the demographic composition of Borneo and contributed to inter-ethnic tensions [42](#). Likewise, the Orang Asli in Malaysia have struggled to maintain their distinct cultures amidst national policies promoting a singular Malay identity [114](#). The struggle for legal recognition of indigenous rights is another shared theme. International law has increasingly acknowledged indigenous rights, but the translation of these principles into national reality remains inconsistent and fraught with setbacks [115191](#). The legal battles fought by Dayak communities in both Indonesia and Malaysia echo the struggles of indigenous peoples in other parts of the world, such as Kenya and Paraguay, who use litigation to defend their ancestral lands against corporate and state encroachment [192](#). These shared experiences

of resistance and advocacy have fostered a sense of solidarity among indigenous movements across national boundaries ¹⁹⁰.

Despite these commonalities, the Dayak civilization possesses several unique characteristics that distinguish it from other indigenous groups in Southeast Asia. First is its sheer scale and heterogeneity. The term "Dayak" encompasses over 50 distinct ethnic groups, speaking more than 170 different languages and dialects, spread across three separate political entities: the Indonesian provinces of Kalimantan, and the Malaysian states of Sarawak and Sabah ²³¹²⁷¹. This vast diversity is both a source of strength and a significant challenge for forging a unified political identity. Second, the Dayak exhibit a strong sense of trans-border identity, with a political consciousness that explicitly rejects the colonial-imposed national boundaries that divide them ¹²⁶¹⁹⁴. This pan-Dayak identity, articulated in movements for a "Great Dayak" territory, is a distinctive feature not commonly seen among other indigenous groups confined within single nation-states. Third, the role of religion is a defining feature of Dayak society. The historic and deep-seated division between the indigenous, animistic faith of Kaharingan and the widespread adoption of Christianity has profoundly shaped Dayak social and political dynamics ³⁸. This religious dimension has fueled both internal divisions and external perceptions of Dayak groups as "fierce warriors," a reputation historically linked to headhunting practices and conflicts with colonial powers ^{38 148}. This complex interplay of indigenous animism, Christianity, and Islam, resulting in high levels of syncretism, sets the Dayak apart from many other Southeast Asian indigenous groups who are predominantly Buddhist, Muslim, or follow different forms of animism ¹⁹⁵²⁰¹. In synthesis, while the Dayak share the universal indigenous experience of resilience in the face of external pressures, their specific history of colonial fragmentation, their remarkable internal diversity, and their unique spiritual landscape make them a compelling and distinct case study in the broader story of Southeast Asia's indigenous peoples.

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